

## ONE-DAY CRICKET

### Miracle at Lord's

It was undoubtedly India's—and international cricket's—finest hour. No comparable event can match the excitement and athletic heights which limited-over cricket achieves. The setting could not have been more perfect—England, where the World Cup originated and which is still the only country that can successfully stage a spectacular show. Starting as unfancied underdogs with London



**KAPIL'S DEVILS:** Team India celebrate after winning the 1983 World Cup

bookies offering 50:1 odds against them, the Indian eleven steered a triumphant if somewhat erratic course to a nail-biting cliff-hanger of a final against the seemingly invincible West Indies, undefeated in one-day cricket and winners of the previous two World Cup titles in 1975 and 1979.

**Dilip Bobb and Sreedhar Pillai, July 15, 1983,**  
INDIA TODAY

India won the 1983 World Cup and everything changed. The way Indians looked at cricket, and in good time, how the cricket world looked at India. Instead of waiting months for a Test win and decades for a Test series win overseas, this version of cricket contained, at the very least, the possibility of victory every few days.

In the 1980s, India played 155 ODIs and won 69. Among these were games of the 1987 World Cup held jointly by India and Pakistan, the first time the Cup had left England. In the 1990s, India played 257 matches of which 104 were played in neutral venues or in 'off shore venues' like Sharjah and Toronto, part of three and four-nation events. All that Indians wanted, it seemed, was one-day cricket. It didn't matter where India played, who they played against, or more importantly, what they played for.

By the time the World Cup came to the sub-continent again in 1996, ODIs in India had found another force multiplier: satellite television. India had the world's biggest television audience for cricket and an appetite for ODIs. When television rights went on sale, cricket discovered its biggest market almost by accident and India the foundation of its financial clout in the game. By this time, the growth of largely meaningless limited-overs tournaments created an unchecked nexus between player, middle man and illegal bookie. A decade-long fraud was perpetuated on the ordinary fan before the outing of Hansie Cronje and match-fixing in 2000.

The glut of ODIs on television worked another inadvertent transformation: it carried the game to parts of India it had not previously reached, places with no pitches, no history, no baggage. It produced a wave of players, from outside the main metros and traditional centres, whose coaches came shrunk into cathode ray tubes and whose skills were born of undiluted ambition. That wave is still coming.

The Indian cricket economy today is estimated to be worth Rs 1,800-2,000 crore per year. There is a new short-game surge, driven by India's unexpected, World Twenty20 triumph and an increasing demand for the format that Gothoskar calls "remix" cricket. Indian cricket's first professional club league around the T20 game is scheduled next summer. India suspects it is onto something big and because of it, cricket knows, or maybe it fears, that it could never be the same again.

KAPIL DEV, Indian skipper, 1983

**"The day we beat West Indies in a ODI in Guyana, it was the turning point in one-day cricket for us."**